How Generative AI Impacts Video Game Development and Shapes the Sentiment of Professionals and Players

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Abstract

The rapid rise of generative AI has created unrest and uncertainty for both developers and players in the video game industry due to the tension between its ambitious technological leaps and the industry's desire to preserve human artistry. This paper explores the current ways in which generative AI is being used in the video game development process along with the sentiments of game developers and players toward generative AI use to determine the effect that the technology is having on the industry and how it should best be used in light of uncertainty, negativity, and fear. For game development, generative AI use has been primarily reserved for backend use such as idea generation and non-creative work such as code assistance despite the potential it has for player-facing features like realistic non-playable characters and dynamic storytelling. Most industry professionals and players have an increasingly negative sentiment toward generative AI use in video games, especially toward creative, player-facing uses such as art generation and story writing, which they fear will replace human jobs and reduce the creativity and originality of games. These findings indicate that generative AI should continue to be used in minimal, backend processes that assist (rather than replace) human workers to maintain the core creative elements of video game design and avoid public backlash.

*AI Statement: Generative AI was used to conduct sentiment analyses of forum posts to gauge video game players' sentiments to generative AI use in video games. All other research was conducted and all written content was produced by the author without the assistance of generative AI.

The Impact of Generative AI on the Video Game Industry

In the past few years, the prevalence of generative AI (GenAI) has skyrocketed, bringing rapid changes to technology and unpredictable shifts in the trajectory of many industries. At the crossroads between this accelerated technology and a multitude of artistic media is the video game industry, which has likewise been shaken by the growth of GenAI. Although video games have always made rapid strides in progress to match technological advancements, few (if any) of these new technologies have been adopted with the same amount of uncertainty and controversy as GenAI has. The same technology that seems to offer an abundance of opportunities for making more in-depth games at lower costs simultaneously threatens the artists, writers, voice actors, and creators that have been the lifeblood of the industry for decades.

This paper offers a deeper look into the ways that GenAI is affecting the video game industry to discern its future trajectory and how best it may be used despite backlash from developers, artists, and players. The paper is split into four sections based on four main research objectives:

1. To understand how GenAI is currently being used in the video game industry and how it may be used in the future.
2. To grasp how those involved in the creation of video games (developers, artists, industry professionals, etc.) view GenAI in their work.
3. To get a sense for player's thoughts on GenAI use in video games.
4. To analyze recent GenAI-related controversies and see what they reveal about the industry's tolerance for GenAI use.

From this research, the paper argues that, although generative AI seems to promise rapid advancement in the quality, ambition, and efficiency of video game development, it remains highly contested by developers and players alike who fear that it may replace artists and developers while producing lower quality, less creative work. Because of this fear of replacement along with public backlash when GenAI replaces artistic vision and appears visibly in the final game release, GenAI is best used as a tool to *assist* human workers with backend and non-creative processes like idea generation, prototyping, and coding.

GenAI's Uses for Video Game Development

GenAI adoption is still quite limited among video game developers. Even so, the interest in what it could potentially offer developing video games is increasing. According to Lambe (2025), nearly 7% of all games on Steam (the most prominent PC video game storefront) by July 2025 disclosed some type of GenAI use, which is up from 1.1% of the total library in April 2024 (from ~1,000 games to ~8,000 games in a little over a year). Lambe's article breaks the GenAI use cases disclosed in these games into five primary categories: generating visual assets, generating audio, generating text and narrative, creating promotional materials, and assisting with code. These uses are diverse and demonstrate that a significant number of developers are already taking advantage of a wide range of GenAI's creative and technical abilities.

However, this data only represents a minority of video games on the market. For many developers, especially the most prominent developers and publishers in the industry, GenAI use is still very experimental, resulting in a disconnect between the theoretical potential of GenAI and the current practical uses for it. While the possibilities of GenAI are ambitious and may appear limitless, the actual use of GenAI is cautious and more realistically narrow in scope.

The Possible Uses of GenAI

The possibilities of GenAI's usage in video game development are expansive and centered around innovating the player's experience through hyper-realism or endlessly generated content. Filipović (2023) explores a handful of these potential applications for GenAI and identifies the creation of hyper-realistic worlds and non-player characters (NPCs) as well as the procedural generation of missions and levels uniquely tailored to the player's experience. By integrating GenAI into the behavior of NPCs that populate a world or into the way the games' stories unfold, developers can make characters seem intelligent and realistic or offer dynamic storytelling through "unplanned narrative digressions and personalized stories." The research paper also highlights the potential of artificial neural networks, which can mimic the human brain's ability to learn from data, as a way of creating this personally-tailored content; the game can 'learn' from the player's actions or dialogue choices and automatically create new content that aligns with the player's decisions, allowing the game to be infinitely complex and replayable (Filipović, 2023). These applications have the potential to revolutionize the way players interact with games, taking advantage of new technology to remove linearity and create the largest and most lifelike worlds the medium has ever seen.

On top of these in-game applications, GenAI has the potential to save developers time and resources by automating tedious and costly tasks. Mukherjee (2025) explains how AI can be used to playtest games and identify bugs or unintended glitches by processing test scenarios much faster than humans can. Not only would AI playtesting be faster and more efficient than traditional playtesting, but it would also reduce the cost of human testers if it reached a point of self-sufficiency. Another way GenAI could accelerate video game development cycles is through its ability to generate game assets. Most modern video games are comprised of an extremely large quantity of visual assets, all of which are typically designed and modelled individually. With GenAI being able to automate this asset creation process, developers can save time and focus their resources on the most important assets while GenAI takes care of repetitive background textures like trees, rocks, and posters, for example (Mukherjee, 2025).

By automating processes like asset creation and playtesting, video game developers would be able to produce games much faster and at a lower cost, encouraging more frequent game releases.

The Currently Practical Uses of GenAI

GenAI is still far from universal adoption in the video game industry, and many of its potential applications are not currently in practical use for a variety of reasons. Firstly, only a minority of developers are using GenAI at all. The Game Developers Conference (GDC) Festival of Gaming conducted their 2026 State of the Game Industry report, featuring survey data from about 2,300 video game industry professionals, and found that only about 36% of professionals were using GenAI in their work (Elderkin, 2026). For those working with GenAI tools, most of the AI's usage came from backend, non-creative tasks such as brainstorming (81% of GenAI users), completing daily tasks (47%), code assistance (47%), and prototyping (35%) and less from creative, player-facing tasks like asset generation (19%), personalized content (12%), and in-game features (5%) (Elderkin, 2026). Most game developers are sticking with traditional development processes, and those that are experimenting with GenAI implementation appear reluctant to weave the technology into the visible parts of their games.

Part of this reluctance to use GenAI for creative processes may come from its technical limitations. Research by Begemann and Hutson (2024) on GenAI's ability to create 2D concept art and use it to generate 3D models found that, while AI generators like Leonardo AI and Scenario AI were able to create fairly unique concept art based on detailed creative prompts, 3D model AI generators like Luma AI and Alpha 3D struggled to create industry-standard models, often generating models that were unnecessarily complex and unoptimized for game engines. These models would need a good amount of manual, human intervention to be considered useable, which may prompt developers to create the models themselves instead. Though GenAI technology has likely advanced since this research was conducted, the general limitations identified by the study highlight the experimental nature of GenAI and present a possible reason why GenAI's usage has been primarily limited to backend tasks.

Of the backend tasks GenAI is assisting with, brainstorming and idea creation seem to offer the most practical benefits. At the 2026 GDC Festival of Gaming, Irena Pereira, founder of the small indie studio Unleashed Games, outlined her team's "Human-Centered AI Pipeline" for development, explaining how GenAI can be helpful in the preproduction stage by solving the "blank page problem," (Lumb, 2026). For her, GenAI can help generate ideas "in a more automated popcorn kind of zone," from which she can select a promising concept and "finish it as a human." In this framework, GenAI helps come up with an incredibly wide range of ideas but creates nothing directly used in the final product, taking advantage of its large-scale data processing and generative capabilities while retaining human creativity and authorship. Capcom, one of the leading game developers and publishers worldwide, announced in a published briefing session summary that they would be following a similar production philosophy. In the summary, the company claimed that they will not be implementing AI-generated assets into their games but will be utilizing the technology to "improve the efficiency and productivity of game development," (Capcom, 2026 as cited in P, 2026). According to Capcom's technical director Kazuki Abe, a major part of these improvements may be focused on streamlining the "idea creating process" for the thousands of objects that populate the complex worlds of their games (P, 2026). Regardless of its size or importance, each object must be uniquely designed, a painstaking and time-consuming task for development teams who must come up with design ideas for every single object. By using GenAI to assist with the creation of these ideas in bulk, developers can focus on actually creating visual assets, saving development time while ensuring the visible objects are human made. These types of backend GenAI use that are not visible in the final product seem to be the most universally applicable in the current video game industry landscape, as they offer practical benefits like saving development time by making certain processes more efficient while avoiding technical limitations and upholding the importance of human creativity.

Video Game Developers' Outlooks on GenAI

The sentiment toward GenAI from developers and industry insiders is growing increasingly negative. While most developers are not fully opposed to the use of GenAI, many are concerned that its ability to generate stories and art will result in the loss of creative jobs and diminish the overall creativity of future video games. In the GDC 2026 State of the Game Industry report, 52% of respondents felt that GenAI was having a negative impact on the industry, up from 30% in 2025 and 18% in 2024 (Elderkin, 2026). Likewise, only 7% of respondents felt that it was having a positive impact, down from 13% in 2025 and 21% in 2024. Neutrality is much less common now as the potential impacts of GenAI are becoming clearer over time, leading developer sentiment in an increasingly negative direction. This negativity appears to be most prominent in artists who feel that their jobs are at risk of replacement. A journal article by Combrinck (2026) on game industry lay-offs and their effects on game artists depicts the sense of fear, scarcity, and tension that has arisen from the GenAI induced lay-offs. Concept artist Sandra Duchiewicz, who was interviewed for the article, explains that she's seen a culture of open hatred towards "AI evangelists" within game studios, as artists find themselves at ethical odds with the proponents of the technology threatening to replace them (Combrinck, 2026). This workplace polarization supports the decline in neutrality highlighted by the GDC survey, showing how GenAI is becoming an unavoidable part of working in the industry. Whether they want to or not, developers are forced to confront GenAI and come to their own conclusion regarding if and how they will use it, resulting in a primarily negative development landscape.

Though negativity and hatred appear to dominate most developer sentiment toward GenAI, there is some openness to specific use-cases for the technology. A survey of experienced game developers by Alharthi (2025) revealed that some developers seem open to using GenAI in their work (80% of the 42 survey participants). Survey responses indicated openness to using GenAI in early-stage creative processes such as idea generation and brainstorming (90.5% of participants) as well as asset creation (83.3%), emphasizing GenAI's ability to quickly iterate ideas at the beginning of the design process. These results align with the practical uses of GenAI previously mentioned as well as the comments from industry professionals at the 2026 GDC Festival of Gaming. According to Lumb (2026), prominent professionals at the event like Chris Hays (lead services programmer at id Software) and David Graham (lead developer of *The Sims 4*) agree that GenAI has potential value as an assistant and accelerator of game development work, especially the code engineering side of it, but should not replace the jobs of engineers who still play a significant role in overseeing the AI.

However, the fear of GenAI reducing the originality of games and replacing developer jobs still dominates much of the industry's attitude toward the technology. In that same survey by Alharthi (2025), most participants expressed a concern about AI automation minimizing human authorship and making games feel generic and uninspired. Some of the participants noted the rising tension between their desire for efficiency and their prioritization of original human concepts and gameplay innovations: if the creative aspects of game development become automated, the creative outputs may become “homogenized,” stripping games of their uniqueness and relatability by taking away the “human creativity [that is] at the heart of game design” (Alharthi, 2025). Survey participants also raise the concern that junior level design positions may be most threatened by the AI automation of repetitive and iterative tasks, further diminishing human creativity by preventing new talent from entering the industry. Without junior level roles, the industry may be at risk for “skill atrophy,” causing an overall decline in talent as the next generation of game developers are untrained, underprepared, or lack interest in such an unpredictable field of employment (Combrinck, 2026).

A potential counterclaim to the fears of creative jobs being replaced is that artists and writers may stand to benefit from the GenAI automation of technical development tasks, since it will allow creatives (as opposed to traditional game engineers), to spearhead the development process. According to game design expert Sam Liberty (2025) in an article on GenAI’s future in game development, most roles in traditional game development studios belong to technical game developers who operate on a “technical-first paradigm” that leave artists and other creatives to operate under their technical constraints. Liberty proposes that GenAI, which appears far more capable of generating code than unique creative outputs, could be used by creatives to replace the technical roles that had limited them in the past, allowing them to subvert the common industry narrative by leading development projects. According to Lumb (2026), however, Liberty’s proposal is still far from reality since the code generated by GenAI has not yet reached a point of self-sufficiency. As long as AI-generated code contains significant errors and relies on engineer oversight, there will still be a need for in-depth technical knowledge alongside the creative aspects of development. Thus, the nature of GenAI's ability to replace game development roles, whether creative or technical, remains uncertain. Even so, GenAI's broader threat to the human creativity of games and junior level development roles continues to produce negativity and fear among the majority of game developers.

Video Game Players' Outlooks on GenAI

Similarly to game developers, the sentiment toward GenAI from video game players is becoming less neutral and increasingly negative. According to a 2024 consumer survey conducted by MIDiA, a digital entertainment research firm, around 60% of the 6,300 players in the survey said that they were neutral on generative AI use as long as they thought the game was good, with positive and negative responses about equal at around 20% each (Elliott, 2025). In response to the survey, Elliott suggests that an increase in media coverage could cause this neutrality to shift into negativity, which is exactly what appears to have happened by the end of 2025. In a survey conducted between October and December 2025 by Quantic Foundry, only 6% of the 1,800 players in the survey were neutral on GenAI use in video games, with 85% of players disclosing a negative attitude toward the technology (Yee, 2025). In one year, neutrality has all but vanished as players continued to encounter GenAI news and come to negative conclusions regarding it, which aligns with the trend of sentiment from game developers. As GenAI continues to be integrated into mainstream culture, it seems likely that this declining neutrality and increasing negativity will continue.

Players also had similar concerns to game developers when it came to creative uses of GenAI in video games. The 2025 Quantic Foundry survey found that player attitudes were more negative toward GenAI use for creative outputs like artwork (91% negative responses), music (88%), and narrative writing (83%) compared to less creative uses like dynamic difficulty adjustment based on player input (43%) (Yee, 2025). These responses suggest that players are more averse to AI-generated content that is a visible part of the final product compared to back-end GenAI uses or GenAI game mechanics that operate in the background and do not diminish the human craftsmanship involved in the game's creation. These findings also align with AI-generated sentiment analyses of the Reddit forums r/videogames and r/ItsAllAboutGames, large community forums focused on general video game news and discussion that together bring in over 1.5 million weekly visitors. According to the sentiment analyses generated by ChatGPT, users are strongly hostile towards AI-generated art, writing, and assets in games, concerned that it will lower the overall creativity and quality of games and lead to an unoriginal and uninspired industry (OpenAI, 2026). The analyses also highlight users' general distrust of corporations and large game companies to use GenAI in productive and ethical ways; users worry that companies will use GenAI to slash labor costs by replacing human artists and developers while keeping game costs consistently high for consumers, maximizing the companies' profit through abuse of the technology. Some users seemed more receptive to GenAI use in games when it did not replace human workers and when its output did not appear as visual creative content, but in backend systems or as early-stage processes like brainstorming (OpenAI, 2026). This increasingly negative sentiment toward GenAI use, especially in its replacement of originality and human craftsmanship, suggests that GenAI should serve as a backend tool for assisting developers rather than an independent designer of released creative content or a replacement of human creators.

It is important to note that the survey data and sentiment analyses are only representative of players who actively participate in online video game discourse or have interest in the industry beyond the surface level. Since video games in general appeal to a broader audience, including casual fans and younger players who may be unaware of GenAI use, the overwhelmingly negative sentiments from vocal players may not be fully representative of consumers and may not be reflected in the sales of video games with AI-generated content. Thus, a video game's target audience should be carefully considered by developers when choosing how to incorporate this controversial technology.

Recent GenAI Controversies

Due to the divisiveness of GenAI use in the video game industry, some controversies surrounding game companies' use of GenAI have emerged in mainstream video game discourse. This section will offer case studies of three prominent controversies caused by GenAI to understand how developers and players react to GenAI use and what their tolerance is for certain use cases.

Fortnite Darth Vader AI-Voice Controversy

In May 2025, Epic Games' *Fortnite* held an event where players could recruit the Star Wars character Darth Vader as an NPC that would fight alongside them. The Darth Vader NPC would also communicate with players through the in-game voice chat, relying on GenAI technology to generate real-time responses to player voice input and render them through an AI-generated voice that replicated the late James Earl Jones' performance of Darth Vader. Although this was done in collaboration with Jones' estate, the Screen Actors Guild - American Federation of Television and Radio Artists (SAG-AFTRA), the largest American union of digital artists, filed an unfair labor practice charge against Llama Productions, the subsidiary of Epic Games responsible for the GenAI use, claiming that they "violated the union's right to negotiate changes to its bargaining agreement," (Taylor, 2025). According to SAG-AFTRA's official statement on the issue, the union "celebrate[s] the right of our members and their estates to control the use of their digital replicas" but is concerned with protecting "our right to bargain terms and conditions around uses of voice that replace the work of our members," (SAG-AFTRA, 2025). The union claimed that Llama Productions was obliged to provide notice to the union before using GenAI to replace a position that a human worker could do, and since they failed to do so, the union could hold them accountable.

However, the specific implementation of the GenAI voice complicated this claim. SAG-AFTRA's concern applies in cases where a company is using AI to replace work that a living voice actor could realistically do. In the case of the Darth Vader NPC's AI-generated voice, a human voice actor could not have read lines generated in real time across thousands of concurrent *Fortnite* matches, so the GenAI voice acting added something unique rather than simply replacing a potential new role through replication. Even if SAG-AFTRA's claim does not apply in this specific case, their charge and statement demonstrated a fear of replacement from digital artists and raised awareness of the potential for GenAI to take the jobs of voice actors in the industry. GenAI's ability to replicate voices adds another layer of concern: if GenAI can replicate classic voices, there will be less opportunities for new voice actors to redefine recurring roles, diminishing the number of voice acting jobs being passed down.

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33 **Indie Game Awards Controversy**

In December 2025, Sandfall Interactive's indie game *Clair Obscur: Expedition 33* received major backlash online for some AI-generated assets featured in the game, most notably resulting in its Game of the Year award being revoked by the Indie Game Awards. According to an article regarding the incident, a representative of Sandfall Interactive claimed that no GenAI was used in *Clair Obscur: Expedition 33*'s development when it was submitted to the awards show, and even though the AI-generated assets were placeholders that had been patched out of the game less than a week after its release, the Indie Game Awards held to their strict regulations that disqualified the game from its awards (Yeo, 2025). If any GenAI use had been disclosed at the time of submission, *Clair Obscur: Expedition 33* would not have been considered according to the Indie Game Awards' eligibility criteria, which states:

> Games developed using generative AI, that have disclosed the use of generative AI, or that include assets created using generative AI in their launch builds are strictly ineligible for nomination. Generative AI includes but is not limited to art (concept, key art, textures, models, etc.), performances, writing, music, and any medium that can be achieved with human artists, writers, or performers. (The Indie Game Awards, n.d.)

In this case, the specific nature of GenAI use did not affect the decision from the Indie Game Awards. The mere fact that GenAI was used in development, even for the small and temporary work of generating placeholder assets, was enough for the awards show to revoke the game's awards.

Since Sandfall Interactive's GenAI use was so minimal, community reactions to the Indie Game Awards' decision were mixed. Some fans felt as though the minor use of GenAI should be permissible since no AI-generated assets remained in the game at that point, but others stood with the Indie Game Awards' decision and applauded the way that they stuck to their strict regulations (Yeo, 2025). By bringing the community's attention to this polarizing issue, the award show's ruling opened the larger discussion of GenAI use in the industry and forced fans to consider how much GenAI use and what kinds of GenAI use constitute as 'too much' to be accepted and praised. More specifically, the Indie Game Awards' eligibility criteria and their strict enforcement of it highlight the fear of GenAI taking away creative opportunities from artists in the industry. To help artists maintain employment opportunities, the Indie Game Awards is choosing to exclusively reward and feature games that are completely free of GenAI use, no matter how small or temporary its output is.

NVIDIA's DLSS 5 Graphics Controversy

In March 2026, NVIDIA, one of the industry leaders in digital graphics technology, announced a new version of their graphics upscaling technology known as DLSS 5 (deep-learning super-sampling). DLSS had used AI in its upscaling process before, but with DLSS 5, NVIDIA employed GenAI to make character faces, lighting, and environments more photorealistic in real time (Ashworth and Larsen, 2026). However, what at first appeared to be a massive breakthrough in graphics technology became the target of sharp criticism by developers and players alike.

For developers, the concern was how the visual changes made by the GenAI-powered DLSS 5 threaten to overshadow the artists' original style and intent (Ashworth and Larsen, 2026). In pursuit of photorealistic graphics, AI-generated graphical changes may undermine certain design decisions that artists intentionally make to emphasize a character's emotions through their facial expressions or an environment's mood through its lighting. And since the player is the one who can toggle DLSS 5 on and off, NVIDIA's technology can overhaul the visual experience without the consent of the developer, reducing their control over their game's art style and direction by rendering it through this "one-size-fits-all" approach to graphical enhancement (Ashworth and Larsen, 2026).

For players, the concern is with the quality of the graphical changes as well as the loss of intentional design. After viewing the DLSS 5 announcement video, which showed comparisons between shots rendered with DLSS 5 toggled off and on, many players considered the upscaled graphics and altered visuals of DLSS 5 to be worse in quality than the original graphics. Many commenters on the announcement YouTube video claim that the upscaling looked like a “social media filter” used to arbitrarily “beautify”, and in some cases, sexualize character faces, most notable with Grace Ashcroft from *Resident Evil: Requiem* (NVIDIA GeForce, 2026). Other comments mentioned how the graphics looked like an AI-generated image, making them appear “uncanny” and akin to “slop.” The YouTube video, viewed by 2.4 million users, currently has 19 thousand likes and 101 thousand dislikes, revealing how most players are against the use of GenAI technology to overhaul intentionally designed visuals for the sake of photorealism.

The reactions from both developers and players further reflect the industry-wide fear of GenAI compromising artistic vision and sterilizing game visuals to conform to a non-human standard of quality.

Conclusion

In theory, generative AI technology has the potential to bring revolutionary changes to the scope and quality of video games while increasing the efficiency and speed of their development. However, GenAI is currently used primarily for backend, non-creative tasks like brainstorming, prototyping, and code assistance, and its output is notably absent from most games’ final releases. This preference for minimal, backend GenAI use makes sense considering the overwhelmingly negative sentiment toward the technology from developers and players alike who are concerned that it will replace engineers and artists while producing less original, lower quality games. The criticism of artistic, player-facing GenAI use, as seen in the three highlighted controversies, remains an active part of mainstream video game discourse and serves as a warning to video game developers and companies to carefully consider the implications of GenAI use to their target audience. Based on these current trends in sentiment and criticism, the best use of GenAI is as a tool that assists human workers with backend processes that make development more efficient without replacing jobs or sacrificing the unique human craftsmanship that goes into a game's design, art, and story. Further research on this subject should continue to monitor the industry's sentiment toward GenAI use in video games while making note of new possible uses of the technology and shifts in community tolerance to these uses.

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